

Start realizing ROI: A practical guide to agentic AI

As enterprises begin transforming processes with agentic AI, achieving realistic ROI is the question on every executive's mind. Learn how your organization can realize ROI with agentic AI and avoid the common mistakes that are holding businesses back.



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Introduction: Agentic AI today

Agentic AI is maturing from concept to competitive advantage at the speed of light. While the technology has only recently come to market, business leaders are already mobilizing to capture its transformative potential. In an IBM Institute for Business Value survey, 76% of executives reported their organizations are developing, executing or scaling proofs of concept for autonomous AI agents.¹

Businesses are thinking past the experimentation phase and seeking real ROI with these agents—61% of CEOs surveyed say their organization is actively adopting AI agents and preparing to implement them at scale.² Autonomous systems are no longer experimental novelties; they've become a business reality.

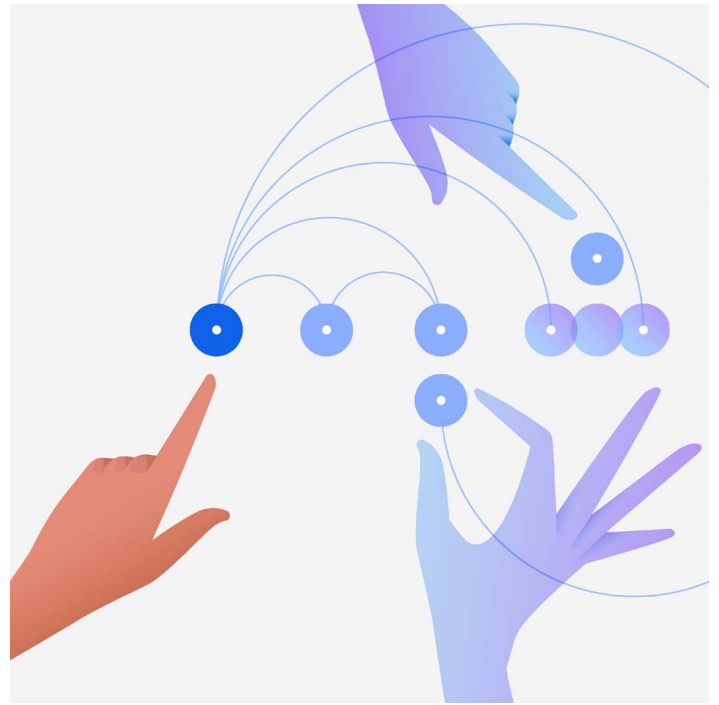
Despite the eagerness to adopt, only 25% of the AI initiatives have delivered the expected ROI and only 16% have scaled

enterprise-wide.² It's no longer enough to pilot a few programs and adopt individual agents. Enterprises must set achievable targets across parameters such as productivity, revenue gains, cost savings, employee and customer satisfaction. And to do so, organizations need to use agentic AI that's integrated and orchestrated, provides robust governance and enables seamless interoperability. They will also need to apply agentic AI to areas that will give them the greatest returns.

Common barriers to ROI on agentic AI

With fast AI adoption comes a host of challenges, as poorly implemented AI can make bad processes worse.

Here are three common barriers that prevent executives from achieving the desired ROI from agentic AI.



Data quality

You can't utilize AI to its full potential without leveraging your own proprietary business data. But if your data isn't well-structured, if it's scattered across silos, your AI initiatives are likely to fail. Agentic AI systems, much like the human workforce, require context to perform effectively. This comes from high-quality, relevant and well-structured data. Without contextual knowledge rooted in business logic, agents operate in a vacuum, leading to errors, inefficiencies and missed opportunities. Organizations must evaluate whether their data infrastructure is mature enough to support autonomous decision-making.

Governance risks

Governance isn't just a compliance checkbox, it's what great AI is built on. Many organizations rush to deploy self-sufficient AI agents and in doing so, they may not spend as much time structuring their systems to manage and oversee the agents. As businesses scale AI across functions and processes, the absence of clear policies, oversight mechanisms and accountability frameworks can lead to unpredictable agent behavior, especially when exposed to real-world data and dynamic environments. As organizations gear up to deploy multiple agents across functions and processes, good governance will prove to be what makes or breaks the agentic AI advancement.

If you don't have proper governance, it will be chaos. Somebody who is in charge of managing risk is going to say stop [...] That's going to take away time-to-market speed. So, it's a critical underpinning of what needs to happen to scale.

Manish Goyal

Senior Partner - Enterprise AI Strategy & Governance,
Global Offering Leader, IBM Consulting

Prioritizing tasks over workflow transformation

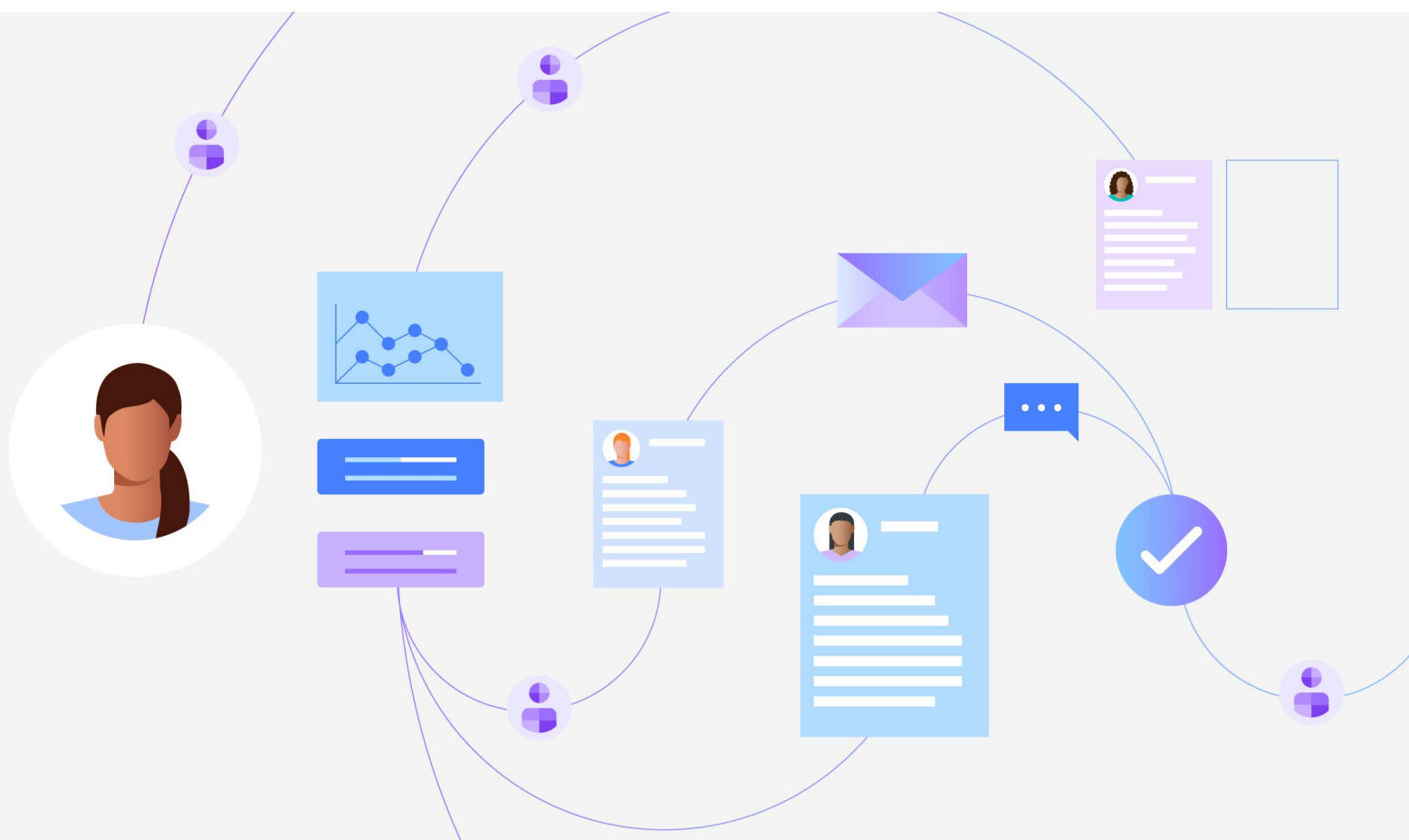
One of the most common pitfalls is focusing on task automation instead of end-to-end process transformation. If your organization is too focused on specific tasks, it can lead to many different, disconnected agents that don't all contribute to the same goal and system. A fragmented agent landscape can lead to the opposite of efficiency: agent sprawl across applications, functions and workflows. Companies and executives must set their sight on AI-first enterprise transformation by integrating agentic AI in core workflows and processes. When this is backed by a robust AI orchestration strategy, agentic AI can offer unprecedented productivity gains and be a key driver of agent-driven business transformation.

Additionally, without an end-to-end transformation strategy, you can only reap marginal improvements in revenue and efficiency, completely missing the bigger opportunity.

When you look at an agentic AI solution, make sure you're going towards the business outcome are you driving. Are you actually hitting the targets that you have defined, or are you just stuck on automating tasks?

Francesco Brenna

VP & Senior Partner - Global Leader AI Integration
Services Consulting



How to maximize ROI on agentic AI

When done right, AI agents can help organizations increase productivity, revenue growth, employee and customer satisfaction and process optimization. Here are four steps to help maximize your agentic AI ROI.

Define what ROI means

Defining ROI goals and relevant KPIs is critical to achieving agentic AI's tremendous potential, whether the goal is cost-cutting, improving speed or automating repetitive tasks. Here are four parameters to measure ROI.

The KPI and the goals you define are really about the business outcome that you want to drive—process efficiency, cost saving, revenue impact.

Francesco Brenna

VP & Senior Partner - Global Leader AI Integration Services, IBM Consulting

Productivity gains

Organizations are focusing on productivity as a key metric to measure the ROI from agentic AI. It allows them to quantify the value agentic AI adds to business operations. When agents automate tasks and accelerate workflows, they directly impact output and efficiency. For instance, IBM uses productivity gains as a way to measure ROI and they expect to achieve USD 4.5 billion in productivity gains by the end of 2025.³ IBM is aiming to become the world's most productive company by automating workflows and reducing manual effort. With agentic AI taking

care of the mundane, time-consuming tasks, employees can spend time on real innovation, leaders can focus on the bigger picture and organizations can unlock unprecedented growth. For example, UFC chose to measure ROI through productivity improvements and implemented systems and processes that helped them gather insights faster, allowing their employees to provide content and responses to their customers at a faster rate.⁴

It's not about measuring agentic AI performance. It's about how well you use these tools in every function within your organization that helps top-line growth and drives productivity.

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ROI unlocked with agentic AI

26,000

D&B Ask Procurement, a procurement assistant developed by IBM for Dun & Bradstreet, helped save an estimated 26,000 hours annually.⁵

75%

IBM AskHR, an internal human resources agent, automated over 80 HR tasks and achieved a 75% reduction in support tickets raised since 2016.⁶

Revenue growth

Revenue growth is another way to measure success. According to a survey, AI-first enterprises are seeing measurable revenue growth and the top-performing companies saw an 18% ROI, well above the average.⁷ More importantly, nearly half of the organizations surveyed report sustained growth in revenue and operating profits attributed to AI since 2022.⁷ To achieve measurable revenue growth, enterprises must focus on building an orchestration layer to ensure AI agents, assistants and automations work together across functions, breaking down silos and uniting the business's investment in agentic AI to create greater impact.

Cost reduction

One of the top benefits of agentic AI is cost reduction, according to 67% of surveyed leaders,⁷ making it another viable option for measuring ROI. Another study shows that 85% responding CEOs expect a positive ROI for scaled AI efficiency and cost savings investments by 2027.² These savings are realized by automating core workflows and streamlining operations in areas such as supply chain, HR and IT, while improving efficiency and scalability. By driving efficiency, agentic AI can help enterprises increase revenue and cut costs at the same time.

Employee and customer satisfaction

Agentic AI can deliver some powerful intangible benefits including improved employee experience, enhanced customer satisfaction and agile and self-serviceable IT systems. In a survey, 44% of responding executives cite improved employee experience and 42% cite talent retention as key benefits of agentic AI.⁸ According to another survey, surveyed executives anticipate a 53% increase in AI-powered personalized self-service options and a 47% improvement in AI-enabled self-service call resolution by 2027.¹ With the right execution, agentic AI can enable employees and customers by automating mundane, time-consuming tasks, freeing them up to focus on more strategic and high-value work.

83%

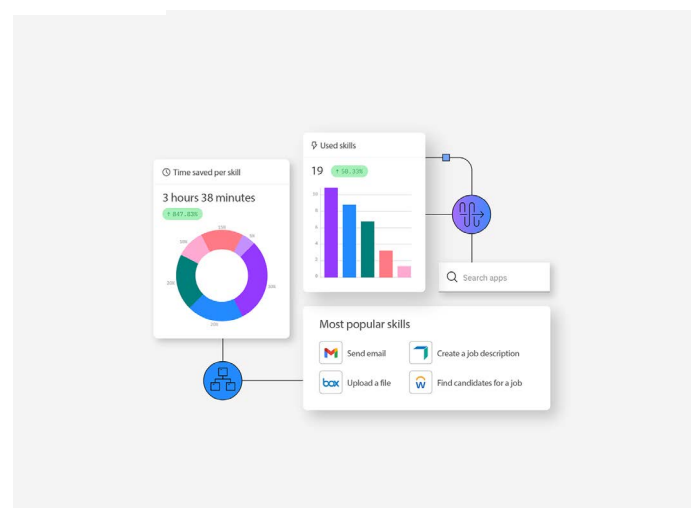
of respondents expect their overall process efficiency and output to improve with AI agents.⁷

<50%

Over the past year, AI-first organizations attribute more than half of their revenue growth and operating margin improvements to AI initiatives.⁷

90%

of responding executives believe AI agents will empower operations professionals to go beyond reporting and deliver real-time, actionable insights by 2027.¹



Prioritize governance

As agentic AI becomes central to enterprise strategy, robust governance is a key differentiator between hype and value. Research shows that 56% of responding CEOs are delaying major investments in generative AI until they have clarity on governance standards.⁹ This hesitation reflects growing awareness that without oversight, AI can introduce risk faster than it can deliver returns. Therefore, it's important for teams to see governance as an essential part of the AI strategy from the get-go.

Agentic AI systems operate autonomously, making decisions and executing tasks independently. Without well-thought-out governance, these systems risk hallucination, bias and non-compliance. A strong AI governance tool introduces agent-specific metrics such as context relevance, trust, compliance and answer quality to monitor agent behavior and detect early signs of drift. Also, ensuring alignment with business goals and regulatory standards is critical for effective governance practices. Notably, 68% of AI-first organizations, those achieving the highest ROI, report having mature governance frameworks, compared to just 32% of other organizations.⁷

If agentic AI is expected to drive both cost savings and revenue growth, governance is critical for successful implementation of agentic AI. It's the foundation for sustainable, scalable and measurable success.

Orchestrate your agentic AI journey

Agentic AI is pushing enterprises to rethink the way they work. However, without effectively orchestrating AI agents' collaboration and communication, automations and data across the business—aligned to defined and desired objectives—organizations risk fragmented efforts and diluted returns. Therefore, to go from marginal gains to enterprise-wide impact, businesses must build a strategic orchestration layer. Not only is it a critical piece of the tech stack architecture in service of an AI vision that creates real value, it also facilitates integration and information-sharing across business functions and workflows. When done right, it ensures that the right data is sent to the right agents at the right time, with the right context and security models. Without proper orchestration, AI agents can struggle to solve critical problems and complete complex tasks.

A great orchestration strategy starts with optimizing workflows for agentic AI. 64% of organizations' AI budgets are being spent on core functions and this is expected to become 70% by 2027.⁷ Furthermore, AI-enabled workflows are expected to expand eightfold by 2026, while executives expect AI agents to transform processes and adapt to workflows.⁷

Orchestration helps organizations move from isolated instances of AI use and automation to cohesive, scalable system that realizes returns.

83%

executives surveyed expect their process re-engineering and workflow reinvention efforts to be more effective because of AI agents.⁷

71%

executives expect AI agents to autonomously adapt to changing workflows and environments. ⁷

75%

executives say AI agents will execute transactional processes and workflows autonomously within two years for 24x7 availability.¹



Turn employees into ambassadors

When it comes to AI adoption, particularly agentic AI, an organization is only as successful as its employees. 81% of executives surveyed recognize that to seize competitive advantage, they need the right people in the right positions with the right incentives.¹ Employees, on the other hand, can be skeptical about AI, which can be damaging to any organization's AI ambitions and overall growth. A Forbes survey shows that 31% of employees admit they're actively sabotaging their company's AI strategy.¹⁰

Executives must rally their employees along with them and turn them into ambassadors, with a top-down as well as a bottom-up approach. One way is to empower employees with AI tools to upskill and augment their work, as IBM did with the IBMer watsonx® Challenge, an annual AI challenge for their employees. The challenge encourages employees to suggest AI solutions that can be executed and scaled, with the 2025 watsonx Challenge seeing over 167,000 participants and a total of 15,555 submissions.¹¹ Organizations can also incentivize employees who embrace the technology, turning skeptics into believers and helping them see that agentic AI is not here to replace but to augment their capabilities.

ROI from agentic AI: A mandate, not just a metric

As businesses move past the experimentation phase for agentic AI, the imperative is clear for leaders: build the processes and governance structures that turn agentic AI from potential to performance. Define your ROI KPIs, prioritize governance and focus on transforming end-to-end processes over automating tasks.

Before you begin your agentic AI transformation:



Clearly define what ROI means



Prioritize governance from the get-go



Have a solid orchestration strategy in place



Empower your employees to become ambassadors

Take the next step

Discover how IBM can help you achieve your ROI goals

Explore IBM's range of AI solutions that can help you transform your agentic AI landscape and maximize ROI.

IBM® watsonx Orchestrate®

Transform your agentic AI portfolio with an enterprise-ready solution that helps create, deploy and manage AI assistants and agents to automate processes and workflows. Enable seamless collaboration between your AI assistants and agents in one unified experience. Leverage ready-to-deploy prebuilt agents or build custom agents to suit your needs.

IBM watsonx.governance®

Build your agentic AI ecosystem on the bedrock of solid governance with an end-to-end toolkit for AI governance to manage risk, compliance and the entire AI lifecycle.

IBM watsonx.data®

Unlock the true potential of agentic AI with the only hybrid, open data lakehouse for enterprise AI.

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